



▲ FIGHTING AT SEA

For the first time, battles were fought at sea using aircraft carriers—huge ships like floating airbases—from which planes could take off and land. There were two major aircraft carrier battles between the US and Japan in mid-1942, first in the Coral Sea off the Australian coast, and then off Midway Island in the central Pacific. At the Battle of Midway, Japan suffered heavy losses and lost control of the Pacific. This turned the course of the war.



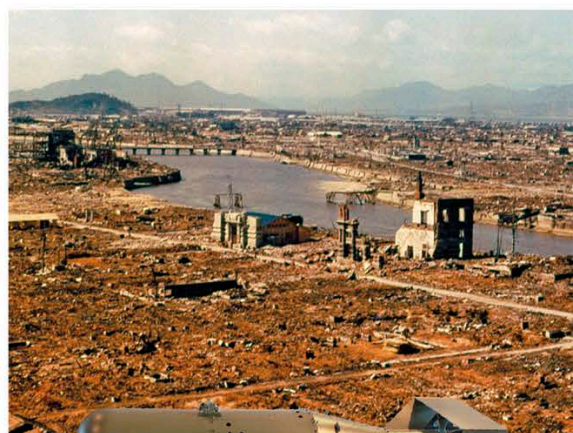
US Marines raise the American flag over Iwo Jima on February 23, 1945.

◀ THE WAR ON IWO JIMA

By early 1945, the US had taken back many of the Pacific islands occupied by Japan. They now needed an island base to launch air attacks on the Japanese mainland. They chose tiny Iwo Jima, just 750 miles (1,200 km) south of Tokyo. The five-week campaign to take the island was one of the bloodiest battles in the war in the Pacific. Once captured, the island was used as a base to launch 66 air raids on Japanese cities.

▼ DEVASTATING JAPAN

On August 6, 1945, a US bomber dropped an atomic bomb named “Little Boy” on the Japanese city of Hiroshima (below), followed by a second bomb on Nagasaki three days later. More than 195,000 people are estimated to have died in the two bombings. Japan surrendered unconditionally on August 15.



“LITTLE BOY” ATOMIC BOMB

EVERYDAY LIFE

At the outbreak of war against Japan in 1941, around 120,000 Japanese-Americans living in the US were locked up in camps by the US government, fearing they might become enemy agents. People were cramped in small barracks and had to survive in very poor living conditions.

